

# The French Revolution and Its Aftermath

From the Fiscal Crisis of the Ancien Régime to the Birth of the Modern Republic, 1774 to 1958

*A political, legal, and social history of France's long revolutionary century.*

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# The Road to Revolution

France, 1774–1788

Between the accession of Louis XVI and the declaration of royal bankruptcy, France underwent a slow-motion collapse of the *Ancien Régime*. Structural debt, failed reform, foreign adventure, and natural catastrophe converged to make revolution not merely possible but inevitable. The next few pages traces those fifteen decisive years, examining the institutional, financial, and environmental forces that dismantled the foundations of absolute monarchy and forced the calling of the Estates-General in the spring of 1789.





# Overview: The Arc of Revolution, 1774 to 1958

The French Revolution was not a single event but a century-long process of political transformation. What began as a fiscal crisis under Louis XVI ended, nearly two centuries later, with the establishment of the Fifth Republic under Charles de Gaulle. Between those two points lay revolution, terror, empire, restoration, civil war, and the slow construction of a durable democratic order. This overview traces the key turning points across that entire arc.

1

## Act I: The Ancien Regime in Crisis (1774–1788)

Louis XVI inherits a throne burdened by structural debt, failed reform, and institutional paralysis. The American War and environmental catastrophe push France to formal bankruptcy.

2

## Act II: Revolution and Republic (1789–1794)

The Estates-General convenes, the Bastille falls, the monarchy is abolished, and the Terror transforms revolutionary idealism into state violence.

3

## Act III: Directory and Empire (1795–1815)

The Directory stabilises and then collapses. Napoleon rises, crowns himself Emperor, spreads revolutionary law across Europe, and falls at Waterloo.

4

## Act IV: Restoration and Reaction (1815–1852)

The Bourbons return, the Napoleonic Code survives, the July Revolution of 1830 sweeps the Bourbons away, and Napoleon III establishes the Second Empire.

5

## Act V: Republic and Commune (1852–1900)

The Franco-Prussian War destroys the Second Empire. The Paris Commune of 1871 reopens the wounds of 1793. The Third Republic slowly consolidates democratic government.

6

## Act VI: The Modern Settlement (1900–1958)

The Third Republic survives two world wars before collapsing in 1940. The Fourth Republic proves unstable. De Gaulle's Fifth Republic in 1958 finally provides a durable constitutional framework.

Each act fed directly into the next. The debt crisis made revolution possible; the Revolution made the Terror possible; the Terror made Napoleon possible; Napoleon made the Restoration possible; the Restoration made 1830 and 1848 possible; and the accumulated failures of every preceding regime made the Fifth Republic not merely desirable but necessary. The arc was neither inevitable nor accidental. It was the product of choices made under pressure, and their consequences.